Thiruvalluvar`s diplomacy and statecraft: Epitome of Bharath`s knowledge and wisdom as Vishwa-Mitra

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Abstract:

The 5th-century saint Thiruvalluvar`s Thiru Kural is a collection of 1330 couplets that encompass the entire moral life aspect of a human being. It is a pride of Bharath`s knowledge and wisdom it had on statecraft even before some civilizations in the West were only in a nascent stage. Thiru Kural speaks about important areas of statecraft in its various chapters including the conduct of a king, the Excellence and spirit of an army, honor, the duties of a minister, and even the duties of envoys. It is an asset that reflects India`s supreme characteristics of righteousness (dharma) and non-violence (ahimsa). The values that Thiru Kural teaches are of contemporary relevance to Bharath`s role and position on the global stage. Thiru Kural adds legitimacy to India`s role in the world as a Vishwa-Mithra and it deserves and is worthy enough to lead the world as a Vishwa-Mithra. This paper attempts to unravel the lessons of Thiru Kural in statecraft, study its relevance to contemporary Indian foreign policy and prove Bharath`s pioneering knowledge and pride in statecraft.

Key words:

Thirukural, Thiruvalluvar, Statecraft, Vishwa-Mithra, Dharma.

Introduction:

The External Affairs Minister of India, Dr S. Jaishankar in his book The India Way, starts the introduction of the book with a couplet of Thiruvalluvar. It is the 426th couplet of chapter 'Arivudamai' which mean wisdom. It says wisdom is to live in tune with the mode of changing world. This is what India is exactly doing in past decades. By analysing the international developments and setting our priorities and interests, it changes and updates it policies to meet its interest. On his state visit to Singapore on 5 September 2024, the honourable Prime Minister of India, Shri Narendra Modi highlighted his speech with the Kural 914 which translates to, ' the world admires those who are known for their sense of justice and service to others', exactly how India is being respected in global stage for its righteousness and its commitment to service. PM Modi also announced about opening of India`s first Thiru Kural cultural centre in Singapore. Indian leaders and visionaries are in a mission to take Thiru Kural to a next level in global stage. It acts as an asset and evidence for India`s knowledge in Indian Knowledge systems and admirable aspects of our age old golden traditions of righteousness and dharma.

Thiru Kural acts as an all encompassing text with covers all the aspects of human life. It speaks about moral, ethical, aspects which is associated with the inner consciousness and self-discipline of a human. These are important virtues a man should follow to justify his birth and life. It covers the physical aspects of a human by why, how, and in what ways a human to human interaction should happen in a moral way, ways to accumulate wealth, maintain wealth. It also covers the emotional aspect of a human being by explaining the importance to give love and being loved. It speaks about ways of loving and other aspects of love. It helps in overall character development of a human being to a live a life to fullest.

In Thiru Kural, Valluvar mentions about the word 'Ulagu' often in various couplets which means world. When the westerns did expeditions and colonized un habited land only 500 years ago Thiru Kural talks about world 2000 years back. He had a global approach in his text which suits for any man and woman in the world without segregating humans in any categories. He also talks about state, army, leadership, kingship and other important areas of state which has got modern relevance. Thiruvalluvar is a visionary where his works have contemporary relevance even after 2000 years since it was written. India`s current position in current global politics has a lot in relevance with Thiru Kural where it is following in an ideal path by what is being said in the Kural. By reading Thiru Kural a man will become a better human being, a king will become a great king, an envoy will become a seasoned diplomat, a minister will become a knowledgeable minister and a soldier will become a courageous

soldier. Overall it is a work for every human being to elevate his/her character, personality, work efficiency, and wisdom to a next level. It is a guide for excellence in all means.

Thiru Kural: Origin and Features

Thiru Kural is a philosophical set of treaties, originally written in the oldest living language of the world Tamil. The specific age of Thiru Kural is yet under debate. Tamil literature scholars argue that Thiruvalluvar is a poet of Sangam era and Thiru Kural is part of the 18 Sangam literatures. The government of Tamil Nadu officially declared 31BCE as the birth year of Thiruvalluvar. It also follows a Thiruvalluvar Calander based on this year. It is said that 1st printed edition of Thiru Kural came in palm leaves and compiled in the 2nd century by the Kalapirars kingdom. However many scholars accept the age of Thiru Kural between 3rd century and first five of the common era. It was written by a saint named Thiruvalluvar. Historian Kamil Zkelebil says that Valluvar might be a native of place called Mylapore which is currently a sub urban area of Chennai city. Valluvar is said to be a Jain saint given the time period and location of his existence. The portrait of Thiru Kural which is now officially used by the government is sketched by veteran artist K R Venugopal Sharma. There is confusion in religious background of Valluvar where some claim he followed Jainism where some scholars says he followed Hinduism. But, the book does not have a specific identity or speaks about a specific god, but nature is worshipped as god. The text was written in Tamil. The original manuscript of palm leaves is believed to be found in early 1800s.

Francis Whyte Ellis, a British scholar wrote about the existence of such work in his book A comparative grammar of Dravidian literatures in 1856. Later multiple scholars had their own interpretation of Thiru Kural and published different versions of it. Thiru Kural is translated in 57 languages and 350 individual translations. In 1886, Thiru Kural was translated in English by George Uglow Pope which introduced Thiru Kural to the Western world.

The text is seen as a moral and ethical hand book for individuals to excel in both personal as well as professional life. It talks about important areas like the State, politics, wealth, envoy, education, friendship, morality, non-killing of lives, peace, harmony etc. It is written in couplet format where each couplet have only 7 words. Totally 1330 couplets are there. These 1330 couplets are broadly categorized into 133 areas or subjects called as adhigaram in Tamil. Each adhigaram has 10 couplets. Whole text is categorized into 3 broad areas namely ‘ Aram, Porul, Inbam’ meaning Ethics or Dharma, Wealth, and Happiness respectively. Aram deals with individual virtues and morality of a human, Porul deals with treaties of

governments, kingship, and society. Finally Inbam deals with emotional aspects like love. With its such a broad areas of understanding, Thiru Kural is considered to be the all in one text for an individual, society and a state to excel in all means. Thiruvalluvar is credited with different names and titles for his invaluable contribution he has given to the Indian knowledge systems.

State defined in Thiru Kural:

Usually texts and scriptures discussing about state, statecraft will be a product of a courtesan written for a specific kingdom or as an advice to a ruler. But, Thiru Kural has a bottom up approach for statecraft where a commoner tries attempt what exactly a state should comprise of how it should function and characteristics of a state. It also acts as a constitution for citizens to understand what exactly a state is. In his second chapter Porul meaning wealth, Valluvar dedicates a separate adhigaram to Land which speaks about essentials of a state. Couplet 731 says a state comprises of 3 important elements. Fertile land which can produce abundant agricultural product, virtuous and knowledge men who can defend the state at all extremes, and merchants with resources who spends it wisely. It can be related to modern theory of state which says a state should comprise territory, population, government and sovereignty. He says state should always have capacity to stay self sufficient and should not be dependent on another state for survival. This resonates with the governments policy of atmanirbharatha, achieving self sufficiency across all sectors. Interestingly he also mentions about immigration in a state. He says a state should be capable of withholding the burdens of influx of immigrant and it should not affects the states productivity.

In his couplet 731, Thiruvalluvar says a state should be free from 3 pertinent evils. They are hunger, disease and enemies. Any state which cannot manage and eradicate these three evils will struggle and perish. Valluvar also speaks about internal security of a state which is a crucial element of state security. Couplet 735 says, there should not be any internal fractions or grouping within a state. There should be no group which stands against the rule of a king. A state should never allow an internal rebellion within a state to happen against the king. Every individual should follow the order and fear the king. Any individual who does not fear the king and tries to topple the government should be executed immediately. It is fascinating that Valluvar has spoken about multiple perspectives of security what we call now as non traditional security issues of a state like terrorism is discussed in his time itself.

A stable state should be able to survive even at times of an invasion. There should be no resource depletion while invasion has happened. Strategic reserves what we discuss now has high security issue has been in practice even 2000 years before in India. He also talks about the importance of fortification of a state in his couplet 737. For him in a state all of its natural resources like rivers, oceans and mountains should act as a natural barriers which stops the enemies. Ideas of his fortification goes beyond building a fort and extends to use natural barriers as fortifications. In couplet 738 he says there are 5 jewels of a state which should be carried all the time. They are un failing health, fertility, joy, security, and wealth. This shows a modern approach of security looking not only from traditional point of security but also human centric perspectives of security. He also talks about preservation of natural resources. He says a state gifted with natural resources are better than state capable of heavy toil and labour. Finally he ends up the adhigaram on state with a couplet which says even though a state is gifted with all such blessing and resources it has no meaning if the state doesn't have a good ruler to manage it effectively .

Valluvar about Right Sceptre of a King

Valluvar gives at most importance to the character and conduct of a king. For him king is the most important element of a state and without king a state can never exist. He discusses about the characters of a king under two adhigarams ' sengomai and kodungomai' meaning the right sceptre and tyranny. Sengomai is right way of ruling for a king and kodungamai is a way a king should not follow. Justice should be the most important virtue for a king says Valluvar. This is analogical to Platonian philosophy which revolves around justice of a philosopher king. A king should be the fountain of justice and should never slip away from serving justice to his people. Couplet 381 says that any king who owns an army, population, wealth, minister, allies, and a fort altogether will be king of all kings. Four Important characteristics of a king should be un doubted courage, liberality, highest knowledge, and wisdom and energy to rule. Also a king should never stop learning in his life. He should accept the wise man`s advice and act accordingly. King should have a courage to take bold decisions. A king becomes a honourable king when he is capable of rooting out all the evils of his people, and never slips away from a moral life and courage. Kural 385 discusses about 4 important duties of a king. A king should be able to produce crops, acquire wealth, conserve the acquired the wealth and distribute the wealth according to the needy. He says a king

should always be soft spoken to his people and be easily accessible. Only when the king is well mannered and well spoken his command will be followed. A king who protects his population at any cost will be treated as god by his people. Charity, Grace, Right sceptre, people`s love should be a central charisma of a king.

Valluvar says that king ii the supreme justice provider in a state. In his Kural 542. He says like the way how world looks upon the sky for rain, the people should look upon the king for justice. He argues that world will constantly embrace the king and loves him un conditionally when the king keeps his population as at most priority. In his couplet 545, he says a king who always acts in accordance with law will never be de throned. Valluvar gives more importance to conduct of the king over his valour and courage. In couplet 546 it is not the sphere and sword of the king which makes him glorified but his right sceptre is what makes him a great king. When a king guards the land in a right way his rule will also be guarded.

The duty of the king should be both cherish the right and punish the wrong. He says executing a criminal who is against the nation is similar to weeding out the field. Like how he advices king on what should be done he also warns what a king should never do under adhigaram kodungomai meaning tyranny. He says a king who fails follow his duty day to day loses his kingdom in day to day. He says when a king does un-justice in a state then there will be no rain in the state. Every drop of tears that comes from the eyes of the oppressed by the king will was away kings glory and power. Valluvar is completely against the tyrannical rule in state and advocate a king to dedicate his entire life to uphold justice and be a moral and ethical ruler. , irremediable

Thiru Kural on Military Spirit and Army.

Valluvar has always glorified the courage of a man as an important virtue. A man becomes a fullest man only when he is fearless and stand by his king any time. He writes about army and military spirit in 2 adhigarams namely Padai seruku and padai maatchi, meaning excellence of an army and military spirit. Padai means army in Tamil. He considers standing army is an important factor of state security. In Kural 761, he says a well organised army which does not fear anything is a rulers greatest strength and asset. He says a real army will never leave the king side at any situations and will be fearless of wound and being killed in the battle field and will never falls short of strength to fight. He talks about different aspects of army including mental fitness and physical fitness of an army. It includes crucial characters like discipline, credibility, organization, and strength. In Kural 764, he says a true

army has long tradition of valour and neither knows defeat nor desertion. He says a good army will never split away and always stands together and fights together even when the enemy attacks with his full might. He says the 4 most important aspects of an army is valour, honour, tradition of chivalry, and credibility. A good army can wade off an impending struggle, can bear against the hostile force with as long as possible. He also speaks about the importance of size of the army. Even when an army lacs tactics and weapons it can win if it has many soldiers to fight. He says an army can triumph any wars if it is free from diminution irremediable aversion and poverty. He argues leadership is one of the most important factor for any army. No matter what the size and strength and size of an army is if it lacs a leader it will perish in a warzone.

In military spirit, he talks about the individual spirit of a soldier and valour and courage of a soldier. He says that a soldier warns his foes in a battle field that soldier who stood against his chief in warzones before are now standing a tombstones. In a battle field a soldier should always dream big and should always intend to fight the best. He says its better to miss the sphere by try killing an elephant than using arrow to kill a hare. His military spirit is a thirst to fight the best in every war and should take pride in killing someone stronger than the soldier. He says people usually consider extreme sense of valour is the ability to fight and kill in the war but the epitome of courage is helping the foe in battlefield when he is helpless. He says soldier should not fear defeat in a battle zone but embrace death with courage and happiness. In Kural 774 he says a soldier who lost his sphere trying to kill an elephant will happily take the sphere which pierces his chest. It is shameful for a soldier to when he fears and closes his eyes when an arrow is coming towards him. A soldier who is ready to give up his life for country should be adorned with anklets in his legs. Even a king cannot hold back his soldier in battle field if he does not fear death in war. He proudly writes that if a soldier can die in way that brings tears in the eyes of the king, the soldier can die as my time to see that precious moment. The spirit what Valluvar impedes to soldiers is of highest might and an epitome of glory.

Thiru Kural about Diplomacy and envoy

Valluvar writes about the need and importance of an envoy for a state to achieve its interest. He sets out the standards, character, morality of an envoy and how and why it is important For diplomacy he has written a separate adhigaram under name Thoodhu meaning envoy. He argues that the important qualities of an envoy should be friendliness, high birth, and nature

pleasing of the kings. Envoys of a start should be well mannered and rightly approachable. The intellectual capacity of an envoy is also equally important as his characters. Kural 682, it says envoy should be loyal only to his king and listen to his king`s orders carefully. Envoy should have a high standard of situational awareness to understand these issues and most importantly a highest standard of speech and communication skills. He also says that only learned scholars and best scholars should be eligible to become a scholar as they handle a highly professional job and hold power. A king should let an envoy to go on a mission only if the envoy has these 3 characters, First is wisdom and high level of morality and ethics. Second feature is personality where the envoy should have a charisma and have a hight standard of behaviour. Third and most important factor of all is the scholarship. Without technical qualification and knowledge one cannot become an envoy. He also talks about the importance of language of an envoy as the primary job of an envoy is debate and negotiations. Envoy should have a strong communication skills. Kural 685 says that the words of an envoy should be compact, un-offending, pleasant and useful. An envoy should have a high decision making skill. He says envoy to be fearless, persuasive to make people accept his thoughts and ideas and should be able to follow a certain norm.

Firstly an envoy should understand the situation very well and the purpose of the mission should be central. He should take as much as required time to achieve the mission and wait patiently until the right time comes and most importantly think very well before speaking a word. He says goodness, friendliness, and boldness are the important characters of an envoy. A kings messenger will not even utter a single word which will bring bad reputation to his king. A brave envoy will not even care about his life and ready to sacrifice his life for the king`s mission. Adhigaram Thoodhu is a best example of what kind of a visionary Thiruvalluvar is. Indian diplomatic community which is one of the world`s highest standards of diplomatic character takes their roots from 2000 year old text which still has contemporary relevance.

Thiru Kural in Relevance With Current Global Issues

The international system that currently exist now is not existing in the expected way. Old conflicts are getting new shape and existing conflicts are spilling over new regions. The pandemic and international health crises across the world is fearing global health. Globalization is so partial that rich keeps becoming richer and poor becomes more depriving and forbidden. A deep question arises whether humans have lost track from their moral

virtues and are guided by un ethical interest. Here is where the importance of work like Thiru Kural is highlighted. While the global community has lost its track and struggling its ways to find its path to get back to a healthy system morals of Thiru Kural can bring back humanity into a highly esteemed system. India, pioneering champion of Global South and acts as the voice of voiceless has a moral responsibility to fix the core issues in the international system. Thiru Kural when take seriously and spread globally and its ideals being followed by leaders and pledge that they take the lessons of Thiru Kural and relate with current issues a workable policies can be made out of it which can make the world better place to live in.

Kural 736, says an ideal state should not disturb peace at any cost. In Kural 474 Valluvar warns that one does not live in peace in with neighbours and be ignorant on issues in the neighbourhood will perish. Lessons of peace from Thiru Kural should be taken seriously in order to solve international conflicts and other issues that were deemed un solvable. India being a Vishwa Mitra of all should teach the lessons of Thiru Kural to its neighbours in order to uphold regional sovereignty and growth.

Role of Bharath in Emerging World: From the Lenses of Thiru Kural

Bharath being one of the oldest civilizations in the world has seen the world taking multiple shifts in the order and changes in the global system. Over the period it has adapted and matured itself to live in the system. Thiru Kural is the classic example to show hoe mature and developed our civilization is 2000 years ago. Emerging order has ambiguous nature and trust issues among nations due to extensive Western scholarly of rivalry and material interest. Bharath has got the moral and civilizational validity which has got ability to solve and sort the issues in formation of new cooperations for global good. Valluvar says the pillar of excellence in any field is 5. They are Love, modesty, altruism, compassion, and truthfulness. Nations in modern context lacks these characters as they are guided by self interest but Bharath should never compromise in taking these 5 virtues to make it a better state.

As a nation which strongly believes in karma and dharma, our deeds as a nation is important. Bharath should stand as a voice for the voiceless and support the needy and stand with righteous behaviour. In such case no evil or cowardly strategy can bring down the great nation. He says even a hill like eminence can be brought down by the deeds which are small as a speck. So the morality, ethics, high standards should stand as an exception for India amidst nations followed by greed, cowardness, and hate. Bharath`s knowledge is the treatment for the long standing ailment of the world. Countries will have issues in accepting

India`s knowledge system and its lessons. But India is nation which strongly belives in one Earth and One World and One Family, centuries ago and this moral sceptre is what should India take globally which resembles its un fading glory.

India a Vishwa Mitra of World:

In adhigaram natpu a dedicated chapter to friendship Valluvar speaks about importance of finding a good friend and being a good friend. In Kural 788, he says friendship is not about sharing good times and cherishing happy memories but real friendship is standing with his friend shoulder to shoulder in his hard times. During Covid pandemic when the developing countries could not afford technology and money to get Covid vaccines, despite the local demand India launched its Vaccine Maitri initiative to gift vaccines to countries which are in need. This is the perfect example of friendship what India follows, which makes it a credible, trust worthy, global friend of all. A good friendship should share the pain of distress for Valluvar. When Sri-Lanka faced a worst economic crises and people were suffering on the streets India swiftly came up with a financial aid package and took care of fuel shortage which shows the true character of friendship. This shows the high stature and moral of a nation together as there was no public condemnation against this move. The throne of friendship is the un failing support given all the time according to Thiru Valluvar.

Despite, India has cooperation with multiple countries with interest specific partnerships the relationship between India and Russia is always cherished and given special status. It is such special because even at hard times countries with contrasting ideas both nations have never failed to support each other at their hard times. Indian scriptures have always had an universal application, and will act as a text for the global goods and global commons. It has never kept its self-centric ideas compromising morality and ethics of a nation. India always stood by the global interest and fostering inclusive growth and development for all. Thiru Kural acts as a strong evidence for Bharath`s Vishwa Mitra dream that it does not have any self centric motive behind its Vishwa- Mitra policy. Rather it is a reflection of great civilizational behaviour, highest standards of morality and ethics. With all such admirable knowledge, India ensures its position as a moral super power which ensure the world grows together as a one family.

Conclusion

Despite Thiru Kural is translated into many languages and in available all over the world the reach its has got to the public forum is very limited. Most saddening part is where Thiru

Kural is being politicized and religious tag given to it. Tamil scholars proudly says Thiru Kural as Ulaga Podhumarai which means a global common text. Thiru Kural is a asset of people that anyone can read it understand it. Best part about Thiru Kural is it inclusive character where it says every human are one at the time of birth and they are differentiated by the moral capacity they develop in their life. It includes multiple subjects into it namely Politics, Economics, Defence and Strategies, philosophy, Ethics, Science, Health. Thiru Kural has spoken about sustainable living and mindful usage of resources. Despite such a high standard of knowledge it has not got much recognition what it deserves.

Thiru Kural is moral hand book of king on how to rule, how not rule, how to form alliances, how to fight a war, How to accumulate and preserve resources and how to serve justice. But sadly very few elected representative within India knows about Thiru Kural. If at all the representatives of India, act accordingly to what Thiru Kural says India will be a heaven on Earth. It is such a easy to read and easy to understand work written in a simple language. It is high time that Indian academic world especially the new education policy which gives emphasis to Indian Knowledge System should take Thiru Kural seriously and propagate Thiru Kural around the country especially among school children whose moral and character is going to determine the future of the nation.

India`s grand vision of Vikist Bharath 2047 can be aided by taking Indian Knowledge Systems seriously. In order to increase the economic output and right way of spending the resources Indian scripture have rightly mentioned on these subjects which should be looked upon and followed accordingly. Indian Foreign Policy has updated itself to the current global situation. Now, India is just no more an observer in global issues but an active engager and enabler in international politics. India has registered its space and has never failed to voice out its opinions and condemnations strongly. India is a potential country to act as a potential mediator and good officers in handling multiple conflicts and most importantly efficient problem solver in international system. At this juncture lessons from Thiru Kural adds validation to India`s Vishwa-Mitra policy and its lessons can help out in bringing practical solutions to global issues.

Valluvar a holy saint is Bharath`s asset in its impounding knowledge and its high commitment to justice. Thiru Kural is a living proof that India is now way lesser to the Greek and Western political ideologies in fact better than those ideals. The saint is to be cherished and his work should be respected, celebrated and most importantly followed seriously which

will make India a country of its own which such a high moral standards, its respect to Dharma is admired and future generations should always feel proud for what their ancestors have left behind for them. Contributions from Thiru Kural is a jewel in its crown of India`s vision for the future world. To conclude Kural 102 which says a timely help even if it is small is greater than the whole value of Earth, analogical to that small help which Thiru Kural can do the humanity and global good.

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